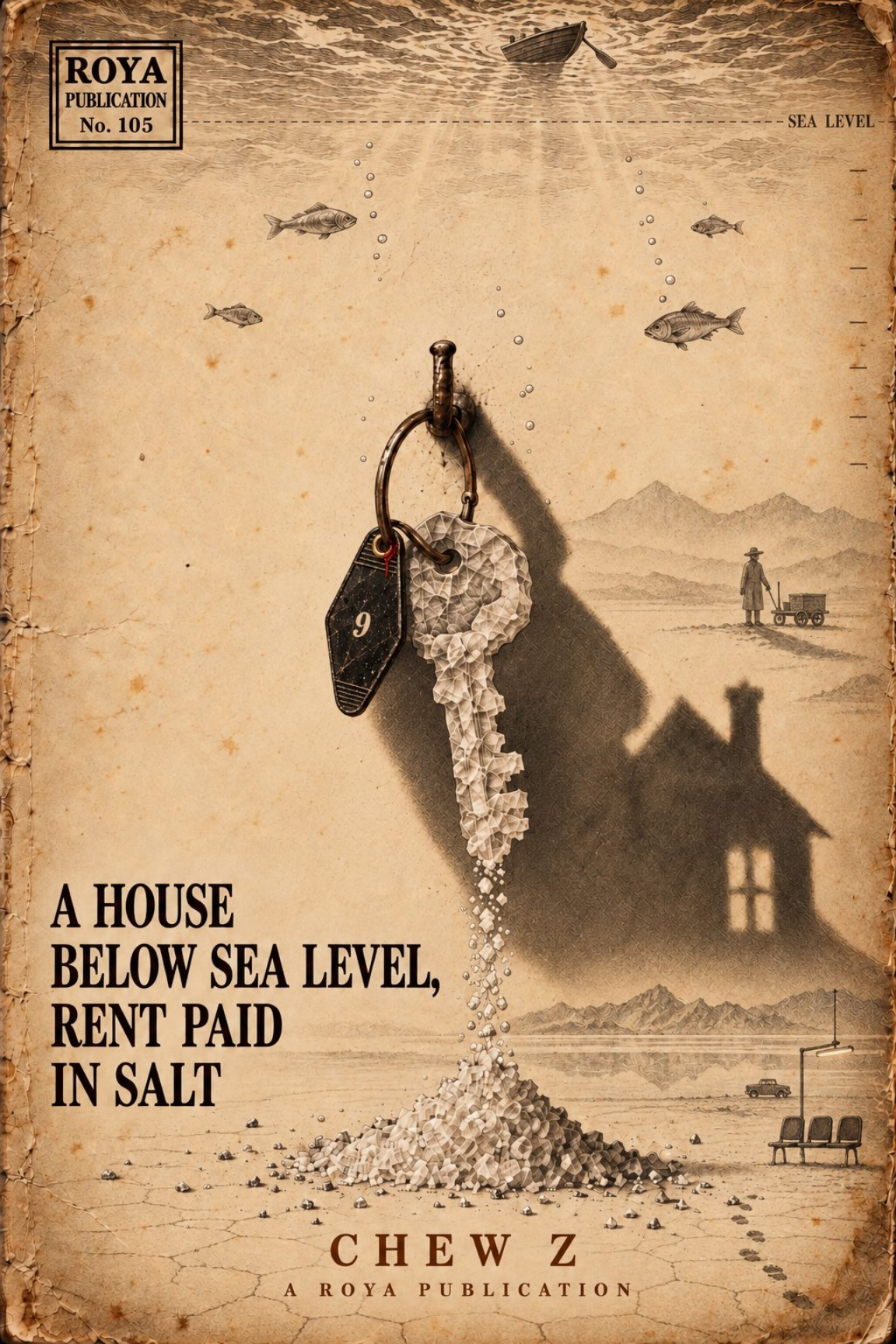


**A HOUSE
BELOW SEA LEVEL,
RENT PAID
IN SALT**

CHEW Z

A ROYA PUBLICATION



A HOUSE BELOW SEA LEVEL, RENT PAID IN SALT

CHEW Z

Printed in the Reach

Roya Publication No. 105

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places and incidents are either the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events or locales is entirely coincidental.

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BELOW SEA LEVEL

A Chart of the Hard Place

0 FT

- ① THE SIGN
Where you started.

- ② THE FIRST LETTERS
The body writes. Politely, at first.

- ③ THE COWARD IN THE TOWER
He shouts at the first smoke.

100 FT

- ④ THE SHADE SELLER'S ROAD
Every reason he gives is true.

200 FT

- ⑤ PICTURES OF WATER
Sky lying on the ground.

- ⑥ THE LONG MINUTE
Big enough to walk around in.

- ⑦ THE WAITING ROOM
For the ones nobody came back for.

282 FT

- ⑧ THE SALT HOUSE
You stop visiting. You live here.

SEA LEVEL

DOWN

IN

IN

IN

SYNOPSIS

Juno Marrow repossesses cars in Bakersfield and sleeps in her own car, or in whichever one she towed that week. She is twenty-seven, quick with her fists and quicker with her mouth, and she has a voicemail on her phone that she has not played in two years.

Abe Coldiron is fifty-one. He fixes air conditioners in Barstow and runs across deserts for no money and no audience. His heart stopped once, nineteen years ago, in the middle of nowhere. He has never asked anyone for help, and he says it is the only record he still holds.

They meet in a motel parking lot in Baker, under the tallest thermometer in the world, when Juno comes to repossess his truck.

Abe is about to walk the route of 1849, the one two young men took in a true story, walking out of Death Valley to find help for the families trapped there. His rule is simple. Two go out. Two come back. His partner has quit. He offers Juno a deal: walk with him, and at the end she gets two thousand dollars and the keys. Out there, nobody she is hiding from will ever find her.

She says she is hiding from nobody. He says then she will love it.

On the first night out, lying on the salt, they find that they have both been dead once, briefly, and that each of them saw the same room. Below sea level, in the lowest place in the country, the room is waiting for them again.

And the walk out was never the hard part.

A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

This book began with a man I have never met, saying something on a screen that I could not stop thinking about. David Goggins, a former Navy SEAL who runs ultramarathons, says the mind quits long before the body has to. He says the only way to grow is to go to the place you most want to leave, and stay there until it stops being a visit. The science agrees with the first part.

I wanted to write about that place. Not a lesson on how to get through it. I wanted to write about what the place is like from inside. What the mind says to the body to get it out. How reasonable it sounds. How it shows you water that is not there. And what happens to a person who is made to stay long enough that the voice runs out of things to say.

I gave the place a name, and I took the name from a sign. At Badwater, in Death Valley, a small sign is bolted high on the rock above the salt. It says SEA LEVEL. You stand far beneath it and look up. Nothing that flows into that valley ever flows out. It leaves only by burning off, and what it leaves behind is salt.

There are two kinds of scar in this book, the kind you get in the body and the kind you carry in your head. I wanted a man who is at home in the first and a woman who is at home in the second, and I wanted each of them to find the other's door. The research on how men and women meet pain is real, and it is set down plainly in the short pages between the chapters. It describes averages. The two people in this book are not averages, and they swap places more than once.

The story of Manly and Rogers is true. They walked out of Death Valley in the winter of 1849 and they walked back in. Juno, Abe, Kit and Lyle are invented. So is the room. Or I think it is.

Chew Z

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I. THE SIGN

1. Juno — Baker, Under the Thermometer

The thermometer in Baker, a gas-stop town on the freeway between Los Angeles and Las Vegas, is a hundred and thirty-four feet tall. I know that because a sign at its foot tells you, and because I had been sitting in my car across the road from it for forty minutes with nothing to do but read signs. A hundred and thirty-four feet, for the hottest temperature ever measured on Earth, a hundred and thirty-four degrees, over in Death Valley in 1913. Somebody in this town thought that was worth a monument. Somebody in this town was right. There is nothing else in Baker to be proud of.

That day it read a hundred and three. October. The cooler part of the year.

I repossess cars for a living. That is the polite word. It means that when a man stops paying for his truck, the bank sends somebody to take it, and in Kern County the somebody is usually me. I work for a tow yard in Bakersfield run by a man named Delbert, who has one eyebrow and calls everybody *chief*. Most nights I sleep in my own car, a '98 Corolla with a hundred thousand miles of other people's driveways on it. Some nights, if it is cold, I sleep in whatever we towed that week. Nobody complains. The owners are not there to complain.

The work order on the seat beside me said: *White 2009 Ford F-150, camper shell. Registered owner Abraham Coldiron, Barstow. Three payments behind.* Under that, in Delbert's handwriting, it said: *last seen Baker, motel by the thermometer. Don't let him talk.*

Next to the work order, face down so I would not have to look at it, was my phone, with a cracked screen and a little red number on the voicemail icon. The number had been a one for two years. It was not going to change. That was the thing about it.

The truck was in the motel lot, backed up to the door of room six. A man was loading it.

I watched him for a while before I got out. You learn more about a man in ten minutes of watching than in an hour of talking. He was carrying blue five-gallon water jugs out of the room, two at a time, and stacking them in the back of the camper like bricks. Forty pounds each. He did not hurry and he did not stop. He was maybe

fifty. Shaved head, gray at the sides where it had been allowed to grow back. A face like something left out in the weather on purpose. Forearms like rope that had been soaked and dried and soaked again.

Every few trips he stopped and put his right hand flat on his chest, and stood very still, and then took it away and went back for more jugs.

I got out of the Corolla and walked across the road with the work order in my hand. He saw me coming. He set two jugs down in the truck bed, straightened up, took a paper bag of sunflower seeds out of his shirt pocket, and put a few in his mouth.

"You're early," he said. "I figured the bank would send somebody Thursday."

"Mr. Coldiron?"

"Abe."

"I'm with Delta Recovery. Bakersfield. You're three payments behind."

"Four on Friday." He spat a shell into his palm. "Outstanding. They sent a professional."

I have been cursed at in this job, chased by a woman with a rake and a Rottweiler, and had a gun pointed at me through a screen door in Taft. Nobody had ever said *outstanding* before. I did not know what to do with it.

"I need the keys," I said.

"I know you do."

"So give me the keys."

"In five weeks," he said, "I'll give you the keys and help you hook it up."

I almost laughed. "That's not how this works."

"I know how it works. I've been on the other end of it before." He looked up the road, north, where the land went pale and flat toward the mountains. "I'm walking out of Death Valley tomorrow. The old way. The way two men did it in 1849. Two hundred and fifty miles

to the coast side of the mountains. I've got water buried along the route. The truck sits at the start for five weeks while I walk. Then it's yours."

"Why are you three payments behind," I said, "if you've got money for water?"

He put his hand on his chest again. He did not seem to know he was doing it.

"Doctors," he said. "My heart stopped once. Nineteen years ago, four minutes, out in the desert. It turned out there's been a hole in it since I was born. It's been sending me bills ever since. This year the bills got bigger than the truck."

I did not say anything.

I did not understand this part until a long time later. When he said *my heart stopped once*, something in me went very still, the way a dog goes still when it hears its name in a crowd. I had never met anybody else who had been dead. Not one person, in eighteen years. I had told almost nobody that I had been. And here was a man in a motel parking lot in Baker, eating sunflower seeds in a hundred and three degrees, saying it like he was telling me the time.

"What was it like," I said, before I could stop myself.

He looked at me. A long look, like I had said something in a language he had not heard since he was a kid.

"I'll tell you," he said, "if you walk with me."

2. Abe — Two Go Out

Her name was Juno Marrow. She told me that after I gave her a bottle of water out of the cooler, which she drank in four swallows without making a face. I told her I fixed air conditioners in Barstow, when I was not walking across deserts. She said that was the most useful job a man could have in a desert and the least interesting. She said Abe sounded like a man who builds boats. I said Coldiron sounded like a man who sinks them. She did not laugh. She looked at me like she was filing it.

"Noted," she said.

We sat on the tailgate in the shade of the camper. The thermometer said a hundred and two now. It was going down for the night, slowly, the way an old man sits.

I told her what the water was for.

In the winter of 1849, a wagon train going to the gold fields took a shortcut. Shortcuts are how most bad stories in the West begin. The shortcut led them down into a long white valley with mountains on every side, and the wagons could not climb out. Some of the people left on foot and some of them died doing it. Two families stayed, with their children, in a camp by a little spring, because they could not carry the children out and would not leave them.

Two young men went for help. William Lewis Manly and John Rogers. Manly was twenty-nine. Nobody knows how old Rogers was. They walked west, across the mountains and across another desert and another, about two hundred and fifty miles, with almost no food, until they came down out of the hills to a ranch near what is now Los Angeles. They got food there, and a few horses, and a little one-eyed mule.

"And then they lived happily ever after," Juno said.

"No."

"No?"

"That's the end of the first half," I said. "I'll tell you the second half on the second half."

"And you're going to walk it."

"From the camp by the spring," I said, "to the ranch. Same line, near as anybody can work it out. I drove the route last month and buried water a day's walk apart the whole way."

"Two hundred and fifty miles. On purpose."

"It's the only way I know to do things."

"So what's the hole in your plan," she said. "You didn't ask a repo woman to come camping because you're lonely."

She was right, and I liked her for seeing it.

"I've got a rule," I said. "Manly had Rogers. Two go out, two come back. In the desert you don't walk alone. If one goes down, the other one goes for help, or carries him out. I don't walk it without a second. My second quit this morning. Called me from a Denny's in Victorville. Said his wife found out."

"Found out what."

"That he was going."

Juno almost smiled. It went across her face and was gone, like a bird past a window. "So you want me to be Rogers."

"I want somebody to be Rogers. I'll pay what I was going to pay him. Two thousand dollars, at the end. And at the end you get the truck. You drive it back to your yard yourself. Your boss gets what he sent you for, five weeks late. You get paid twice."

"I'm not a walker."

"Nobody's racing. It's walking. I watched you cross that road like you owned it. I've got everything else — food, salt, a tarp, a first aid kit that could do surgery."

She was quiet for a while. The light went gold and then orange, and the thermometer's numbers got brighter as it got darker, red bulbs against a sky going purple.

Then she turned her phone over and looked at it. I saw the little red number on the screen before she turned it away from me. She typed something with her thumb, quickly, and put the phone face down on the tailgate between us.

"What did you tell him," I said.

"I told Delbert the truck wasn't here." She did not look at me. "I told him I'd keep looking."

"And the rest of it?"

"Out there," she said. "No phone. No signal?"

"Most of the way, no. Nobody can reach anybody out there. That's the other thing I was going to say to sell you on it."

"I'm not hiding from anybody," she said.

"Then you'll love it," I said.

3. Juno — The Lowest Place in America

He drove us in that night. I left my Corolla in the motel lot with a twenty under the wiper for the manager and a note that said I'd be back for it, and I did not think about Delbert again until much later, and then only once.

The road goes down into Death Valley like a road going into a well. You can feel it in your ears. You drive and drive and the land falls away on both sides and the mountains get taller without growing, because it is you that is getting lower. Abe had the window down. The air that came in was warm at ten at night, like the breath of something asleep.

He stopped at a pullout and turned off the engine and the lights, and the dark came down so hard I thought for a second I had gone blind.

"Get out," he said. "Look up."

I have lived my whole life in the Central Valley, under a sky the color of a dirty sink. I did not know there were that many stars. I did not know they came in layers, the near ones and the far ones and the far-far ones behind those, like dust on a black floor that went on downward forever. I stood there with my head tipped back and my mouth open and I did not say anything clever, which is rare for me, and Abe did not say anything at all, which I would learn was usual for him.

We slept at Badwater. That is where he wanted the first night to be, at the lowest point, though the real camp of 1849 was thirteen miles south. "Start at the bottom," he said. "It's the only honest place to start."

We walked out onto the salt in the dark with headlamps. The ground was white and broken into shapes, six-sided plates the size of tables with ridges between them, like the skin of something huge and dried. It crunched under my feet like old snow. Abe threw down a pad and a sleeping bag and lay on his back in the middle of all that white, and after a while I did the same.

"Up on the cliff behind the parking lot," he said, "there's a sign. You'll see it in the morning. It says SEA LEVEL. We're two hundred and eighty-two feet under it."

"That's a lot of water we're not under."

"That's a lot of everything we're not under."

I lay there and the salt ticked and settled under me as it cooled. I thought about the ocean being up there, invisible, a ceiling of nothing three hundred feet thick. I thought about drowning without the water.

"Can I ask you something," Abe said.

"You can ask."

"How'd you get the scar on your chin."

"Boxing."

"You box?"

"Did. Three years."

"Why'd you stop?"

"I started winning," I said.

He thought about that for a while. He did not ask what I meant, and I liked him a little for it.

"Can I ask you something," I said.

"You can ask."

"You said you'd tell me. If I walked with you. I'm walking."

He did not answer right away. The salt ticked. A long way off, something called once and stopped.

"So what was it like," I said. "Being dead."

"Waiting room," Abe said. "Bad lighting. Nobody called my name."

I laughed. I could not help it. It came out of me like something knocked loose. "Same," I said. "I think they lost my file."

He turned his head on the pad and looked at me in the starlight for a long time.

"You too," he said.

"Nine years old," I said. "Not as long as you. A minute and something. I don't remember the number."

"What happened."

"Hot car."

He did not say *I'm sorry*. He did not say anything. He just lay there next to me on the floor of the lowest place in America, and after a while he started to laugh too, not at me, at the whole thing, at the two of us lying there with our two little deaths, and I started again, and we laughed until it hurt, and then we stopped, and it was very quiet, and I fell asleep before I could be embarrassed about it.

4. Abe — The Families

In the morning I showed her the sign.

You have to know where to look. The cliff goes up behind the parking lot, brown and red and broken, and high up on it, small as a postage stamp, there is a white board with black letters. SEA LEVEL. Tourists stand on the salt and point up at it, and you can see them feel how far down they are.

Juno looked at it a long time.

"Somebody had to climb up there to put that," she said.

"Somebody did."

"So they'd know how far down everybody else was."

"That's one way of seeing it."

"What's the other way."

"So everybody else would know which way was up."

She looked at me sideways. "That's very deep, Abe. Did you get that off a tea bag?"

"Fortune cookie. Panda Express. Barstow."

"Outstanding," she said, in my voice, flat, and I did not let her see it hit.

We drove south to the camp. The real one. I parked the truck in the gravel at the edge of it, cracked the windows, and put a note on the

dash for the rangers: GONE WALKING. BACK IN FIVE WEEKS. DON'T TOW. There is not much there now. A spring that the books call Bennett's Well, which is less a well than a place where the ground is a little greener than the ground around it. Some mesquite, a thorny desert tree that grows wherever there is water underground. A sign from the Park Service. In 1849 this was where two families stayed and waited for twenty-six days with their children in the cold, eating their oxen one at a time, watching the mountain to the west where the two young men had gone over.

I told her about them while I set out the packs. The Bennetts and the Arcans. Asabel Bennett and his wife Sarah, and their three children. Jean-Baptiste Arcan [zhahn bah-TEEST ar-KAHN], a Frenchman, and his wife Abigail and their little boy, Charles. One of their oxen was called Old Crump, and he carried children on his back for two hundred miles and came out alive, and they say Bennett swore afterward he would never eat him, and never did.

"That's the most heartwarming thing you've ever said," Juno said. "It's about not eating a cow."

"Ox."

"Noted."

She picked up the pack I had set out for her and put it on and adjusted the straps without being shown, which told me something else. She had carried weight before, and not for fun.

"So the two young guys," she said. "They walk out. They get the food and the one-eyed mule. They come back?"

"That's the sequel."

"And?"

"Nobody reads the sequel," I said.

I said it like a joke and she took it like one, and I was ashamed of it. It was a true thing dressed up as a joke so that I would not have to say it. I knew the second half of the story the way you know where a stair is in the dark. I was not going to tell her yet.

We stood at the edge of the camp with the packs on. The sun was up over the Black Mountains behind us, and ahead of us the

Panamints, the wall of mountains on the valley's west side, were going from gray to pink. There was no wind. There was no sound at all except a small bird somewhere in the mesquite, saying the same two notes again and again, like somebody trying to remember a phone number.

"Two go out," Juno said.

"Two come back," I said.

We walked.

Interlude I — The Sign on the Cliff

Water comes into Death Valley from every side — off the mountains when it rains, which is almost never, and underground from springs that were rain ten thousand years ago. A river called the Amargosa [aa-mar-GO-sah] — the word is Spanish for bitter — comes down from Nevada and turns into the valley and gives up there.

None of it ever leaves.

There is no way out downhill. Geologists call a place like this a sink, like the one in your kitchen, except that this one has no drain. The only way out for water is up — to lie on the ground under the sun until it turns to air and rises.

When it goes, it leaves behind what it was carrying. Salt, mostly. That is why the floor is white. It is the leftover of every drop that ever arrived and could not leave.

High on the cliff at Badwater, a sign marks where the sea would be if the sea were here. You stand two hundred and eighty-two feet beneath it.

Some places in a person are built the same way. Things flow in. Nothing drains. The only way out is to burn it off, slowly, standing in the heat.

What is left when you do is salt.

II. WALKING OUT

5. Juno — The First Letter

The first thing nobody tells you is that it does not come all at once.

For the first hour, nothing is wrong. My legs were legs. The sun was a sun. We walked up a long gravel fan toward the mountains, the kind of slope that looks flat until you are on it, and I talked. I talked about Bakersfield, which is not a subject. I talked about the tow yard, and about Delbert's eyebrow, which deserves its own chapter and is not going to get one. I was a tourist. I was having a nice time.

Abe walked beside me and answered when he had to. He walked like a man who had made a deal with the ground a long time ago and was keeping his end of it.

The second hour, the body sent me a letter.

It was polite. A small tightness at the back of my left heel, where the new boot rubbed. A dryness at the back of my tongue. Nothing you would stop for. It was the kind of letter that says *just so you know*. I read it and put it in my pocket and kept walking.

By the third hour I had stopped talking. Not because anything hurt. Because I had run out of things to say, and when I ran out, there was nothing there to take their place.

That was what got me. Not the heat. Not the slope. The quiet.

You do not understand how loud your life is until you take the noise out of it. In Bakersfield there is always something. The tow truck radio. The freeway. Your own phone buzzing on the seat, face down, the little red number under the glass. Even at three in the morning there is the clank of the chain and the voice in your ear going *come on, come on, come on*.

Out there, there was nothing. The crunch of our boots. My breathing. A little wind that came and went like something sniffing at us. And under all of it, getting louder as everything else got quieter, the inside of my own head.

It is a terrible neighborhood, my head. I have avoided it for years.

My body was fine. That was the joke. Three years of boxing and six years of hauling chains had made me into something that could

walk all day and barely notice. By noon Abe was sweating through his shirt and I was barely damp. My legs were bored.

It was everything above my neck that wanted to leave.

At the lunch stop, under the overhang of a boulder the size of a house, Abe handed me a bag of salted almonds and watched me eat.

"You're quiet," he said.

"There's nothing to look at."

"There's everything to look at."

"There's rocks."

"That's what I said."

I ate the almonds. I could hear myself chewing. I could hear my blood. I thought, very clearly, the way you think something on a staircase in the dark: *I could just walk back down. I could walk back down to the truck and take it and be in Vegas by dinner.*

I did not say that. I said, "How far today."

"Eighteen miles."

"Noted," I said, and stood up first, so he would not see how much I wanted to sit there forever.

Interlude Ii — The Coward in the Tower

A hundred years ago, a scientist in England named Archibald Hill had men run until they stopped. He thought the muscles would simply run out, the way a car runs out of gas.

It was not quite that. The muscles still had something left. The men stopped anyway.

Seventy-some years later, a doctor in South Africa named Tim Noakes said the brain has a watchman. He sits up in a tower and watches the body, and long before anything is in real danger, he starts shouting. Stop. You're going to die. He makes the next step feel impossible. Not because it is. Because he would rather you stopped a mile too early than a foot too late.

Other scientists have argued with the details ever since. Nobody argues with the shape of it. Most people, when they quit, have a great deal left in them. They never find out how much, because the watchman is very convincing, and he has had their whole life to practice.

He is not your enemy. He is the oldest friend you have. He kept every one of your ancestors alive long enough to have children, and he has never once been thanked.

He is just a coward who loves you.

6. Abe — Where I Live

There is a place I go.

Some people call it the pain cave. A Navy man I heard calls it the forty percent, because when your mind says you are done, you are only forty percent done. Mostly I do not call it anything. I just go there.

It usually starts around mile thirty of a long day. On this walk it started around mile sixty, on the third afternoon, on the long climb out of Panamint Valley, the next valley west of Death Valley, toward the pass. Ahead of us the road went up in switchbacks and the sun sat on my neck like a hand.

First the world gets smaller. You stop seeing the mountains and the sky. You see the next ten feet of ground and nothing else, and the ten feet keep arriving and you keep stepping on them. Then the noise starts. Not out loud. Inside. It is the noise of every part of your body filing a complaint at once, and the complaints all come to the same desk, which is you.

Most people, this is where they leave. I understand it. It is a terrible desk to sit at.

But I have been sitting at it for thirty years. If you sit there long enough, the complaints start to repeat. The knee says what it said an hour ago. The feet say what they said yesterday. Nothing new is arriving. It is the same mail, again and again. And once you notice that, you can stop opening it.

That is when I hear the other voice. The one I hired.

I hired him at boot camp in San Diego when I was eighteen: a drill instructor named Staff Sergeant Oliver, with a voice like a shovel going into gravel. When I left the recruit depot I took him with me. I never fired him. He just stayed.

Is that all you got, Coldiron? Is that the whole show? Your knee hurts? Outstanding. Write it a letter. Your heart's doing the thing? Your heart's been doing the thing for nineteen years and it hasn't killed you yet, it's not going to start on a Tuesday.

It was Thursday. Oliver was never good with days.

I could hear Juno behind me. Her breathing was easy. She had not said a word in an hour and I knew it was not her legs.

"You good?" I said over my shoulder.

"Never better," she said. "This is my favorite mountain."

"You've never been on a mountain."

"That's why it's my favorite."

At the top of the pass I stopped and turned around. Panamint Valley lay behind us like a dropped plate.

My heart was going too fast. I could feel it in my throat. I put my hand on my chest, the way I do without knowing it, and I waited, and Oliver said in my ear, *What are you waiting for, Coldiron? A parade?*

I wanted to sit down. I wanted to sit down more than I have ever wanted anything. That is the thing about the place I go. It never gets easy. It just gets familiar. I know where the furniture is.

There is one more thing I do down there, and I have never told anybody, because it sounds like something off a poster in a dentist's office.

I keep a jar.

Not a real one. A jar in my head, on a shelf, with a lid. In it is every hard thing I ever came through. Boot camp in San Diego in August. The hill outside Pristina [PRISH-tee-nah], in Kosovo [KOH-soh-voh], the Balkan country where they sent us as peacekeepers in 1999. Hendricks on my back, his blood running warm down the inside of my collar. Badwater the first time — the race, a hundred and thirty-five miles from the bottom of Death Valley up to Whitney Portal, a trailhead high on the side of Mount Whitney — when I threw up at mile ninety and finished anyway, on my hands for the last few yards up the hill to the line. The night in Ridgecrest, the nearest hospital town to the Panamints, when I woke up with a tube in my throat and a nurse telling me I had been dead and was not anymore.

When the desk is full and the mail is all bad, I take the lid off the jar and take one out. I do not live it over. I just hold it up to the light

and look at the man in it, the man on his hands on the hill at Whitney Portal, and I say to him, *You did that. That was you. This is smaller than that.*

It works. I do not know why. It works every time.

And then, when I have put the lid back on, I do the other thing. I look forward. Not at the next ten feet. All the way. I make myself see the finish. On this walk, it was always the same picture: the last ridge, and the green valley below, and the cattle, the way Manly saw it. I could see the grass. I could feel what my legs would feel when they stopped.

Jar behind. Valley ahead. You stand in the middle of the two and you walk.

What I did not let myself think about was that the valley was a parking lot now, and that the jar had one thing at the bottom I had never once taken out.

That place is where I live. Some men have a cabin by a lake. I have this.

"Outstanding," I said, out loud, to nobody, and I started down the other side.

7. Juno — The Shade Seller

I met him on the fourth day.

I want to be careful how I say this, because I know how it sounds. I did not see anybody. I did not hear a voice out loud. But somewhere in the middle of the morning, walking across a flat between two ranges, a voice started talking in my head, and it was not mine.

It was nicer than mine. That was how I knew.

You know you don't have to do this, it said.

It said it like a friend. Like the friend you have at two in the morning, the one who agrees with you about everybody.

He's not paying you enough. Two thousand dollars for two hundred and fifty miles? That's eight dollars a mile. That's less than you

make towing. You could be in Vegas. You could be in a pool. Do you remember pools?

I did remember pools. There was one at a motel in Delano [duh-LAY-noh], a farm town north of Bakersfield, run by the family that fostered me for six weeks when I was ten, and I swam in it every day until my eyes were pink, and it was the happiest six weeks of my childhood, and I had not thought about it in seventeen years.

There's shade up ahead, the voice said. See that rock? Just sit down for a minute. He'll understand. He's an old man. You'd be doing him a favor.

I looked. There was a rock up ahead, with a scoop of shade under it the color of cold coffee. It looked like a living room. It looked like the best place I had ever seen.

You're smart, the voice said. Smarter than him. He's doing this because something's wrong with him. Look at him. He keeps grabbing his chest. He's going to die out here and you're going to have to carry him and you don't even like him.

"I like him fine," I said out loud.

Abe did not turn around. He did not slow down. He said, "Who are you talking to?"

"Nobody."

"Tell him I said hi."

I laughed, and the voice stopped for a second, like somebody interrupted.

Then it came back. It always comes back. It is very patient. It has a thousand reasons and every one of them is good. That was the worst part. Everything it said was true. The money was bad. The old man was sick. The shade was right there. My feet did hurt now, a little. It was not offering me anything evil. It was offering me a chair.

I started calling it the Shade Seller. A man on the side of the road with a cart full of shade, selling it cheap. Real shade. Good shade. And the only price was that you stop walking.

We passed the rock. I did not sit down. The Shade Seller did not seem to mind. He walked along beside me for the rest of the day, pointing things out. *There's a nice one. Oh, look at that one. You'd fit under there.*

That night, at the camp, Abe was taping his feet by headlamp and I said, "Do you have one?"

"One what."

"A voice. That tells you to quit."

He did not look up from his feet. "Everybody's got one."

"What's yours sound like?"

He thought about it. "Like my mother," he said. "God rest her. She was a very reasonable woman."

"Mine sounds like a guy selling shade."

Abe stopped taping and looked up at me, and the headlamp put a white circle on my chest.

"That's good," he said. "That's a good name for him. Most people never give him a name. They think he's them."

Interlude Iii — Why Leaving Feels So Good

In the 1930s, a young scientist at Harvard named B. F. Skinner built a box, and scientists after him put rats in boxes like it. The floor could give a small electric shock, and on the wall was a lever. When the rat pressed the lever, the shock stopped.

The rat learned to press the lever very quickly. What the scientists noticed was how deep the lesson went. Relief, it turned out, is one of the strongest teachers there is.

People are the same. Every time you leave a hard place, the mind gets a little reward. The pain stops. The awful conversation ends. And the mind writes it down: this worked. Do it again. The next time, it is easier to leave. Until leaving is not something you decide. It is something your feet do before you have noticed.

This is how most people build a soft life. Not with one big choice. With a thousand small reliefs, each one sweet, each one teaching the lesson again.

The Shade Seller does not need to lie to you. He only needs you to remember how good the shade felt the last time.

8. Abe — The Heart Thing

The fifth night I woke at two in the morning and my heart was going like a dropped washing machine.

I know the feeling. I have known it for nineteen years. The doctors call it atrial fibrillation, which means the top part of the heart has stopped beating and started shivering instead, and the bottom part is trying to keep up with a shivering it cannot understand. It is not supposed to kill you, mostly. It is supposed to make you sit very still and think about your choices.

I sat very still. I counted. One, two, a gap, three four five, a gap, six. Like a man falling down stairs.

There is a pill I am supposed to take. I had it. I took it. Then I sat with my back against a rock and my hand flat on my chest and looked up at the stars, which in that part of the desert come down so low you could knock them over with a broom, and I waited for it to sort itself out.

I did not hear her get up. Juno moves like a cat, or a repo woman, which is the same animal. She was just there, sitting on her heels on the gravel a few feet away, her sleeping bag around her shoulders like a cape.

"What's going on," she said.

"Nothing."

"Your face is gray."

"It's the starlight. Everybody's gray in starlight. You're gray."

"Abe."

"It's a heart thing. It's an old heart thing. It does this. It'll stop."

She looked at my hand on my chest and then at my face and then she reached out and put two fingers on the inside of my wrist, cool, like a nurse, and I let her, because I did not know what else to do.

She held them there a long time. Her lips moved. She was counting too.

"That's not a heartbeat," she said. "That's a drum solo."

I laughed. It hurt a little. "Outstanding," I said. "A critic."

She did not laugh.

That frightened me more than my heart did. Juno laughed at everything. I had watched her laugh at a scorpion that tried to get into her boot. She had laughed at my death, on the salt, the first night, and I had loved her a little for it. Now she was sitting in the dark with her fingers on my wrist and her face completely still, and she was not laughing, and I understood that whatever she saw on my face was worse than I thought it was.

After a while the stairs stopped falling. One, two, three, four. Steady. Boring. The best sound in the world.

She took her fingers away.

"How many times has it done that," she said.

"Out here?"

"Out here."

"Twice."

"You were going to tell me when?"

"I wasn't."

She looked at me. Then she looked away, out at the dark, at the line of mountains we had come over, black against the black.

"You're an idiot," she said quietly. "You know that? You're a giant gray idiot."

"I've been told."

"By who?"

"Everybody," I said. "But you're the first one who took my pulse first."

9. Juno — Pictures of Water

On the sixth day I saw a lake.

We had come down out of the mountains into another valley, a wide flat one, with a dry lakebed in the bottom of it, white as paper, and on the far edge of it a town with smokestacks that Abe said was Trona, where they dig salt and soda and borax out of the old lake

and the whole place smells like a swimming pool somebody set on fire. We were walking along the edge of the lakebed. It was noon. Nothing moved.

And out on the white there was water.

It was blue. Real blue, deep blue, the blue of a picture in a dentist's office. It lay out there across the whole flat, shining, with little ripples on it, and the mountains on the far side stood in it upside down. I stopped walking. I could not help it.

"Mirage," Abe said, behind me.

"I know it's a mirage."

"Just saying."

"I *know*."

I knew. I had seen them on the freeway, the wet look on hot asphalt that always goes away when you get there. This was the same thing, only bigger. Only a whole lake. I could feel it not being there. And I could not stop looking at it.

Then I saw the car.

It was parked at the edge of the water. A tan Buick, an old one, with a dent in the back door and a coat hanger for an antenna. I knew that car. I knew every inch of that car. I had been inside it with the windows up in August.

The Shade Seller did not say anything. He did not have to. He just showed it to me.

I started walking toward it.

I heard Abe say my name. I heard it the way you hear somebody call you from another room. I was walking out onto the lakebed, and the crust was breaking under my boots, and the car was right there, a quarter mile, less, the sun shining on the windshield so I could not see who was inside, and I thought, *if I get there, if I just get there, I can open the door, I can open the door this time.*

I walked for a long time. The car did not get closer. That is the thing about pictures of water. You can walk toward them all day and they will keep their exact distance, polite, patient, like something that loves you and will not let you touch it.

Then the light changed. A little cloud, the only one in the sky, went over the sun. And the lake was gone, and the car was gone, and I was standing a mile out on a dry white lakebed by myself with my shadow under me like a hole.

When I turned around, Abe was standing at the edge of the flat where I had left him. He had not followed me. He had not called again. He was just standing there with his hands on his pack straps, waiting, small as a fence post.

I walked back. When I got there he handed me a water bottle without a word and I drank half of it.

"What was it," he said.

"A lake," I said.

He nodded. He did not believe me. He did not push.

We walked on. The Shade Seller was quiet for the rest of the afternoon. I think he was pleased with himself.

Interlude Iv — The Sky on the Ground

A desert mirage is not a trick of the mind. It is real. You can photograph it.

On a hot day, the ground heats a thin layer of air just above it. When light from the sky comes down at a low angle and hits that hot layer, it bends, and curves back upward toward your eye.

So when you look out across a hot flat and see water, you are seeing the sky, bent by the heat and laid down on the ground, shining. It even ripples, because the hot air ripples. Your brain has only ever seen blue shining on the ground one way, and so it tells you, with total confidence: water.

The mind does the same thing from the inside.

When it wants you out of a hard place, it does not always argue. Sometimes it shows you a picture. A pain that has not happened yet — the body warning of damage long before damage arrives. A memory you have kept locked for years, suddenly so clear you could walk into it. A very good reason to stop, perfectly lit.

None of it is quite a lie. The sky is real. The memory is real. The pain is real enough.

But every picture of water is a piece of sky, lying on the ground where it does not belong.

10. Abe — Nobody Asked

The cache at mile one hundred and twelve was gone.

I had buried it a month before at the foot of a cut bank, under rocks, six blue jugs and a box of food. I had marked it on the map and taken a picture of it with a Polaroid camera because I do not trust phones. The rocks were there. The hole was there. The jugs were not.

There were tire tracks. Somebody had driven right up.

Juno stood looking down into the hole like it was a grave. "Somebody stole our water," she said.

"Looks like."

"Who steals water in the desert?"

"Somebody thirsty."

She turned on me. "This isn't funny."

"It's a little funny."

We had about a liter and a half between us. The next cache was twenty-two miles on. It was a hundred and one degrees. I knew those numbers and so did she, and we both knew what they added up to.

There was a road two miles south. On a road in that part of the desert, sooner or later, there is a mine truck or some kid from Ridgecrest in a jacked-up Toyota. You could flag one down.

I said we would walk to the next cache.

"No," Juno said.

"We'll go slow. Walk at night. Twenty-two miles. We'll make it by morning."

"With your heart doing the drum solo."

"My heart's fine."

"Your heart was not fine the other night, Abe, I had my fingers on it, it was doing jazz. There's a road two miles that way. We walk to the road. We wave at a truck. They give us water. We say thank you. We are grownups."

"No."

"Why?"

I did not have a good answer. I had a true one, the same one I have had all my life, and I have never once said it out loud, because it sounds like a child's reason. *Because I don't ask.*

"Manly and Rogers didn't have a road," I said.

"Manly and Rogers didn't have *a road*. Abe. They didn't have *roads*. It was 1849. You want to fight a bear?"

"There's no bears out here."

"I'll *find* you a bear."

"You lied to your boss about my truck," I said.

She stopped. Her mouth opened.

"So I covered for you," she said, "and you get to die of thirst."

"So you don't get to lecture me about the right way."

"I'm lecturing you about the *alive* way! The right way is your stupid rule! The alive way is a guy in a truck with a gallon of Arrowhead!"

We were standing in the full sun, screaming at each other next to an empty hole, two dead people with a liter and a half of water. A raven came down and landed on a rock about thirty feet off and watched us with its head on one side like a man at a tennis match.

Juno pointed at it.

"Even *he* thinks you're an idiot," she said.

The raven said something hoarse and rude.

"See?" she said. "He agrees with me."

And I started to laugh. I could not stop it. It came up out of me from somewhere under the ribs, the place the heart thing lives, and it bent me over. Juno stared at me with her fists still clenched, and then her face cracked too, and she sat down hard in the gravel laughing, and I sat down next to her, and the raven watched the two of us howl beside the grave of our water, and after a while it lost interest and flew away.

When we were done we sat there breathing.

"We're walking to the cache," Juno said. "Aren't we."

"Yes."

"You're a stubborn gray idiot."

"Yes."

She wiped her eyes. "Noted," she said.

We walked all night on a liter and a half. It was the worst night of my life, and I have had some. We got to the cache at six in the morning and the jugs were there, all six, and I have never in my life seen anything as beautiful as a plastic jug with water in it, not the ocean, not a woman, not the stars. Juno drank until she was sick.

Then we sat on the cut bank in the first sun with the jugs between our knees and something happened that I have never been able to explain to anybody who has not done a hard thing on purpose.

We were happy.

Not relieved. Relief is the shade closing over you. This came up out of the ground through the seat of my pants. The sun came over the mountains and lit the whole flat gold, and every rock had a sharp shadow, and I could see further than I have ever seen, and everything I could see I had walked through. Juno lay back on the gravel with her arms out like a kid making a snow angel and laughed at the sky for no reason at all.

"What is this," she said. "What is this."

"This is what it's for," I said.

"This?"

"This. Every bad mile. This is the receipt."

She lay there with her eyes shut. "It's better than drugs," she said.

"You'd know."

"I would," she said. "It is."

There is a scientific word for it, I am told, some medicine the body makes in its own blood when you have suffered long enough. I do not care what it is called. I have been chasing that morning for thirty years and I will chase it until I die.

Neither of us said anything about the road. But I knew, and she knew, and I think the raven knew, that there had been a hand held out to me on that flat, a very easy one, and that I had not taken it, and that it had nothing to do with Manly and Rogers at all.

III. THE PARKING LOT

11. Juno — Time Goes Wide

Somewhere in the second week the days stopped having edges. I could not tell you which day we crossed the long valley with the dry lake and the railroad, or which night we slept in the wash with the coyotes going off like a car alarm. They all ran together. One long day with dark patches in it.

And inside the day, time went wide.

I would be walking, counting steps, because counting was the only thing that kept the Shade Seller from getting a word in. Somewhere around sixty I would lose the count, and look up, and have no idea how long I had been walking. A minute. An hour. The sun had not moved. A single minute would open up in front of me like a room, and I would walk into it, and walk around inside it, and it would not end.

I thought I was going crazy. Then I thought, no, this is what crazy is for. Your mind gets so tired of the outside that it starts building rooms.

On the fourteenth night we camped in a wash under a cottonwood that should not have been there, the only tree for ten miles, with a trickle of real water under it that Abe said was a spring nobody had a name for. We had made a fire, which we did not usually. The firelight came and went on Abe's face. He was sitting with his hand on his chest again.

I told him.

I do not know why that night. I think I had walked around inside that minute for so long that there was only one thing left in it I had not looked at, sitting in the corner like a box.

"The hot car," I said.

He did not say anything. He put a branch on the fire.

"My brother's name is Kit. He's five years older. Our mom worked doubles at a cannery and then she didn't work at all and then there was a guy, and then there wasn't. Kit raised me. That's not a figure of speech. He made the sandwiches. He did the forms. He was fourteen."

The fire popped.

"It was August. He had Mom's car. He wasn't old enough to drive and he drove anyway, he drove all the time. He parked outside a Rite Aid. He said, *wait here, ten minutes, don't open the door for anybody*. And he went in."

I could feel my heartbeat in my teeth.

"He didn't come back. Turned out he got caught. Stealing. Something stupid. A security guy held him in the back. Hours. And I stayed in the car. Because he said wait. And the thing is, Abe — I could have gotten out. The doors opened from the inside. I could have just opened the door and gotten out any time I wanted. I didn't. Because he said wait, and I wanted to be good. I wanted him to come back and see I'd been good."

My voice did not sound like mine. It sounded like it was coming from the bottom of a pool.

"A guy walking by saw me. He broke the window with a rock. I was already — I'd stopped. They said I'd stopped. At the hospital they said my heart wasn't going when the ambulance got there and then it was. A minute and something. I don't remember the number."

"Then what," Abe said. Very quietly.

"Then they took him. Kit. Because he left a nine-year-old in a hot car. Two years in juvenile hall. They took me too. Foster homes. Mom never got either of us back. That was the end of all of us. Because of me. Because I sat in a car like an idiot when I could have just opened the door."

"Juno."

"And when I was sixteen he came to find me. He was out by then. He came to the placement in Delano, a different house this time, and stood on the porch. And I wouldn't see him. I told the lady to tell him I didn't live there. I watched him from the window. He stood there for twenty minutes and then he left. So I left him. You see? I left him twice. Once in the car. Once on the porch."

The fire was down to coals. I could not see Abe's face anymore, only the shape of him, the hand on his chest.

He did not say it wasn't my fault. He did not say I was a child. He did not say any of the things people say. He just sat there in the dark with me, and let the thing I had said stay in the air between us, and did not try to clean it up.

I think it was the kindest thing anyone has ever done for me. Everybody else always tried to take it away from me. He just let me have it.

After a long time he said, "You want the last of the cocoa?"

"Yes," I said.

He made it. We drank it out of the same cup, taking turns, and neither of us said anything else that night.

Interlude V — The Long Second

A scientist named David Eagleman wanted to know if time really slows down when you are afraid. He dropped volunteers backward about a hundred feet into a net from a tower at an amusement park, with a small screen on their wrists flashing numbers too fast to read. If time slowed for them, they would read the numbers.

They could not. Time did not slow down.

But afterwards they said the fall had taken about a third longer than it really had.

Fear does not slow the clock. It makes the mind write down everything. A frightening second is recorded in full, an ordinary one barely at all, and a full memory feels long.

In the hard place, the clock does not change. You just stop throwing the seconds away.

12. Abe — Out

We came down out of the last canyon on the nineteenth day.

I had been walking toward that place for almost forty years. The first time I read Manly's book, *Death Valley in '49*, the story he wrote down as an old man, I was twelve years old, in the Barstow library, which was air conditioned and was therefore the best place in Barstow. I read the part where the two young men come over the last ridge and see the green valley below them, and cattle in it, and they know they are going to live. I read it until the page was soft.

And here it was. The last ridge. The valley.

There were no cattle.

There was a roller coaster.

It came up over the hill in front of us like a spine, red and yellow and blue, a thing of steel loops as tall as a building, and as we stood there a train of little cars went screaming up it and over the top and down, and from a mile away we could hear the people in it. Screaming. Happily. That is the worst kind.

Beyond it there were more, and a parking lot the size of a small country, shining with cars.

I had known. I had known for years. Rancho San Francisco [RAHN-cho san fran-SIS-ko], the cattle ranch where Manly and Rogers came down to food and life, is under a theme park now, or near enough. I had seen it from the freeway. I had never come at it the way they did, out of the desert, on foot.

"Abe," Juno said. "Is that—"

"Yes."

"We walked out of Death Valley—"

"Yes."

"—for three weeks—"

"Nineteen days."

"—to get to *Magic Mountain*?"

I did not say anything. The roller coaster went over the top again. The people screamed.

Juno started to laugh. Not her usual laugh. Something bigger, from further down. She bent over with her hands on her knees and laughed until she could not breathe. I tried to keep my face straight. I lasted about four seconds. Then I was laughing too, standing there on the last ridge of the Manly route with two hundred and fifty miles of salt in my socks, laughing at the most beautiful and stupid thing I had ever seen.

We walked down across the parking lot. People looked at us. I did not blame them. We looked dug up. A little boy in a Batman shirt stared at Juno with his mouth open, and she leaned down and said, very seriously, "Don't ride the big one. It's not worth it."

And under all of it, under the laughing and the tiredness and the shame of how we smelled, I felt it again, the thing from the morning at the cache. It came up through the soles of my boots off the hot black asphalt of the Magic Mountain parking lot. I looked at Juno and I could see it in her too, in her face, under the dirt. She did not have a word for it. I did not give her one. Some things you should be allowed to find out for yourself.

At the edge of the lot, there was a curb in the shade of a pepper tree. We sat down on it.

That was it. That was the end of the first half.

Juno laughed again, quietly, and then the laugh turned into something else, and she put her face in her hands, and then turned and was sick into the ivy behind the curb, very neatly, and sat back up and wiped her mouth.

"Sorry," she said.

"Don't be."

"I think I'm just tired."

"You're just done," I said. "It does that. When you stop, everything you didn't let yourself feel comes in all at once. It's like opening a closet."

She looked at me. "You're sitting very still."

"I'm resting."

"You've got your hand on your chest again."

I took it away. I put it on my knee.

She did not say anything. Neither did I. Behind us the roller coaster went over the top and the people screamed, again and again, like something being born.

13. Juno — The Easy Door

Abe got us a motel with a pool in Valencia, the town that has grown up around the theme park.

He did it without asking. He just walked up to the desk looking like something the desert spat out and put a card down and came back with two keys. Two rooms. Next to each other. He handed me mine and then he handed me an envelope.

"Two thousand," he said. "I said I'd pay you at the end."

I looked at the envelope. "This is the end?"

"This is the end of what I asked you for," he said. "You walked out. Two went out. Deal's done. I'll get the truck back to your yard myself."

He went into his room and shut the door.

I stood in the parking lot of the motel with the envelope in my hand. It was the most money I had held at one time in my life. I could feel it through the paper, the thickness of it. It felt like a door.

The pool was blue. Real blue. The blue of a picture in a dentist's office. It did not go away when I walked toward it.

I took off my boots and my socks, which had become something else, a kind of leather, and I sat on the edge of the pool with my feet in the water. My feet were white and swollen and the skin on the bottoms had gone strange, like the skin on old milk. The water was cold. I sat there and cried a little bit, without making any noise, because my feet were in a swimming pool and nothing hurt.

The Shade Seller sat down next to me.

He did not need to say much. *Here it is*, he said. *Here's the shade. You earned it. There's a bus station in Santa Clarita. There's a bus to Vegas at eight. Two thousand dollars in Vegas. A pool every day.*

You're the toughest person you know. You don't owe anybody anything.

All true. Every word of it.

I took out my phone. I had turned it off on the first day. I turned it on. It took a long time to find a signal, and then it buzzed, and buzzed again, and there were texts from Delbert, and missed calls from numbers I did not know, and there in the corner, the little red number. One.

Two years.

I pressed it. I held the phone to my ear.

There is a little click when a voicemail starts, and then a breath. Before the words. Somebody breathing in, getting ready.

I heard Kit breathe in.

I pressed stop.

I sat there with the phone in my lap and my feet in the pool, and my heart was going so hard I thought I might go into the water. I sat there until the sun went down and the pool lights came on, underwater, green and blue, and the water glowed like something alive.

Then I heard Abe's door open.

Interlude Vi — Two Kinds of Hard

Scientists who study how men and women meet pain and effort have found real differences, on average. They are only averages, and every person is a mix.

In long, steady efforts — hours, not seconds — women's muscles tend to tire more slowly than men's. The longer the race, the closer women come to men. In 2002 and again in 2003, a woman named Pam Reed won the Badwater race outright, in July, ahead of every man. Other women have since won some of the hardest races on earth outright.

In the mind, the differences run the other way. When something hurts, women more often turn it over and over, talk about it, reach for other people. Men more often push the feeling down, keep quiet, and carry it alone. Research finds that men ask for help far less than women do, even when the help might save their lives. One old study found that men will hold their hand in ice water longer when a woman is in the room watching.

Each way of being hard has a soft place hidden in it. The one who goes over and over the pain can get lost in it. The one who pushes it down can carry it until it breaks him.

And each person, somewhere, has the other's skill — unused, waiting, like a tool in a drawer they have never opened.

14. Abe — The Sequel

I came out of my room and sat down on the plastic chair beside her. The pool light made her look like something drowned and come back.

"You going to Vegas?" I said.

"How'd you know?"

"Everybody goes to Vegas from here. It's the law."

She did not say anything.

I had been sitting on the motel bed for two hours with the curtains shut, my heart doing the thing on and off, trying to think of a way to say it that did not sound like a beggar, and there was not one, so I came out to say it like a beggar.

"I'm going to tell you the second half," I said.

She looked at me.

"Manly and Rogers got to the ranch. They got food, and a few horses, and the little one-eyed mule. They could have stayed. Nobody would have blamed them. There was a whole state of California to go and be rich in."

"But they went back."

"They went back. The whole way. The horses died on the way. The mule didn't. That little one-eyed mule climbed rock a goat wouldn't. Twenty-six days after they left, they walked back into the camp. The two families were still there, sure the two boys were dead. When Manly fired his gun, a man came out from under a wagon and threw his arms up and shouted, *The boys have come! The boys have come!*"

I stopped. I had not meant to stop. My voice had done something.

"Then they all walked out together," I said. "And when they got to the top of the last mountain, somebody looked back down at the valley and said, *Goodbye, Death Valley*. That's where the name comes from. It's a goodbye."

Juno did not say anything for a long time. The pool filter hummed.

"That's not why you're doing this," she said. "Is it. It's not for the history."

"No."

"Who's Lyle?"

I looked at her.

"You talk in your sleep," she said. "Every night. You say *Lyle* and you say *I'm coming*. Every night, Abe."

So I told her.

Nineteen years ago I did this walk with a man named Lyle Pruitt. We had been in the Marines together. He was the only friend I ever had who could keep up with me and the only one who could make me laugh while doing it. We started at the spring, at the camp, the same as she and I had. Same route. Two go out.

On the third day, in a side canyon in the Panamints, Lyle stepped on a loose rock and broke his ankle. It was bad. The bone was wrong. He could not walk.

We had a choice and I made it. I left him in the shade of a cliff with most of the water and went for help. There was a dirt road eleven miles east. I said I'd be back by morning with a truck. *I'll be back by morning*. Those were the words.

Seven miles from the road, my heart stopped.

I do not remember it. I remember the ground coming up. I remember a feeling like a door closing in another room. Then I remember the waiting room, the bad light, the carpet. Nobody called my name. And then I remember a hospital ceiling in Ridgecrest, three days later.

A man in a Jeep had found me. A rockhound, looking for quartz. He did CPR on me in the gravel for four minutes until my heart came back. Then he put me in the Jeep and drove. I was out for three days. When I woke up I told them about Lyle. I told them where he was. They sent a helicopter.

He had been there four days. He was sitting up against the cliff where I left him. The water was gone. He had written something on the rock beside him with a stone, and it said *ABE COMING*.

"So I didn't come," I said. "I walked out and I didn't walk back in. My heart stopped and that was the reason, and it was a good reason, and he's dead anyway. Nineteen years. I've done Badwater eleven times. I've done every hard thing I could find. None of it was the right one."

Juno's feet moved in the pool. Little circles.

"So you want to walk back in," she said. "To the camp."

"The whole way."

"With your heart doing the drum solo."

"Yes."

"And you need two."

"Two go out," I said. "Two come back."

She looked at me for a long time. Then she said, "Are you asking me?"

And I could not do it. The words were right there behind my teeth. *Will you come with me.* Four words. I have carried a man down a hill in Kosovo. I have walked a hundred and thirty-five miles through a hundred and twenty degrees eleven times. I could not say four words to a repo woman by a motel pool.

"I'm telling you the second half," I said. "That's all."

She looked at me a while longer. Then she nodded, slowly, like somebody deciding not to say something.

"Noted," she said.

IV. WALKING BACK IN

15. Juno — Noted

I did not go to Vegas.

I would like to tell you there was a moment. A light from above, a decision. There was not. I sat by the pool until the pool lights went off at eleven, and then I went to my room and lay on the bed in my clothes and did not sleep, and in the morning I went and knocked on Abe's door.

He opened it. He looked like he had not slept either. He had his boots on.

"I'm coming," I said.

He did not say *thank you*. He did not say *why*. He looked at me for a second with his face doing nothing, and then he nodded once, and stepped back to let me in, and that was how I knew he was saying thank you. Abe says everything important by not saying it. It is the most annoying thing about him and I would not change it.

"For the money," I said. "I want another two thousand."

"Done."

"And I want a better pack. Mine pulls on the left."

"Done."

"And I want to know why you bought a deer cart."

It was leaning in the corner of his room. Two big wheels, an aluminum frame, a pair of handles like a wheelbarrow, and straps. Hunters use them to drag a dead deer out of the woods.

"For the water," Abe said. "The caches are spent. We drank them on the way out." He looked at the cart. "We need a mule."

"That's not a mule. That's a stretcher with wheels."

"Manly had a one-eyed mule."

"Manly had *a mule*."

"Then it's a one-eyed mule," Abe said, and he took a black marker out of his pocket and drew an eye on the left side of the frame. One eye. It looked surprised.

"I hate that I love it," I said.

We walked out of Valencia that afternoon with twelve gallons of water lashed to the one-eyed mule, and a plan to fill up again in Ridgecrest and Trona, past the parking lot of Magic Mountain, back up into the hills the way we had come. I did not look back. I knew what all of it looked like now. That was the difference. Going out, everything was new, and new things carry you. Going back, every rock is a rock you already met.

The Shade Seller walked along beside me, quiet for once. I think he could not understand why anybody would walk back into a place they had just gotten out of. I could not have explained it to him. I could not have explained it to me.

All I knew was that if I got on that bus I would be getting on it for the rest of my life. And I knew that the way you know a stair in the dark.

16. Abe — The Wrong Direction

Walking back in is worse.

Nobody tells you that, either. You would think it would be easier. You know where the water is, the shade, the bad rocks.

But going out, there is something pulling you. A finish. A green valley. You lean into it like a rope.

Going back in, there is nothing pulling. There is only something you are walking toward on purpose, and every step, the body asks you the same question. *Why are we going this way? We got out. Why are we going back?*

And you have no answer the body can understand. The body does not understand *Lyle*. The body does not understand *promise*. The body understands water and shade and away from the heat. You are asking it to walk back into the oven on purpose, and it is not stupid, and it knows it.

On the fifth day back, in the long valley with the railroad, my heart started doing the thing and did not stop.

Before, it had come and gone. A night, an afternoon. Now it stayed. All day. I took the pill. I took another one. It slowed but it did not

stop. I could feel it in my fingertips, a stutter, and in my mouth, a taste like pennies.

I did not tell her.

I hid it badly. I knew I was hiding it badly. I walked behind her instead of in front, so she would not see my face. When we stopped I sat with my back to her. When she asked how I was I said *outstanding* in a voice that was not outstanding at all.

Oliver was in my ear all day. *Is that it, Coldiron? A little flutter? You've walked through worse. You walked Badwater with a sprained ankle. You walked the Kosovo hills with a man on your back. Your heart wants to quit? Your heart doesn't vote.*

And for the first time in thirty-three years, I heard something underneath Oliver. Another voice. Quieter. Not the Shade Seller.

You could ask her, it said.

That was all. Four words. It did not tell me to stop. It did not tell me to go back. It just said: *you could ask*.

It frightened me more than my heart did.

That night we camped in the wash under the cottonwood with the spring nobody had named. The same place she had told me about the car. She made the fire this time. I sat with my back against the tree and she sat across from me.

"How bad," she said.

"What?"

"Abe."

I did not answer. She got up and came around the fire and sat on her heels beside me and put her two fingers on my wrist, the way she had that night in the mountains.

"It's been going all day," she said.

"It's fine."

"It's going like a washing machine full of shoes."

"It's fine."

"There's a road," she said. "Four miles. Back the way we came. We can be at a hospital in Ridgecrest by tomorrow."

"No."

"Why?"

I opened my mouth to say the same thing I had said at the empty cache, *Manly and Rogers didn't have a road*, and it would not come out. What came out was something else.

"Because if I stop now," I said, "I never go back. I know myself. I go to Ridgecrest and they put me in a bed and I lie there and tell myself I'll do it next year, and I never do. Like last time. Nineteen years of next year."

Juno did not say anything. She kept her fingers on my wrist.

"I'm not asking you to stay," I said.

"I know you're not," she said. "That's the problem."

Interlude Vii — Laughing in the Dark

People have always made jokes in the worst places on earth.

In the trenches of the First World War, soldiers put out newspapers full of jokes about the mud, the rats, and the generals, printed on a press they had found in the ruins of a town. Emergency-room nurses, firefighters, police — people who work beside death — are famous for a humor that would shock anyone who overheard it. Researchers have found it helps them. Not to make light of what they see, but to keep them able to look at it at all.

A man named Viktor Frankl, a doctor, spent three years in the death camps of the Second World War. He lost almost everyone he loved there. Afterward, in a book about how a person survives the unsurvivable, he wrote that even in the camps, people joked. He and a friend promised each other to invent one funny story every day, about something that might happen after they were free. He called humor another of the soul's weapons in the fight for self-preservation.

In the hard place, a joke is not disrespect. It is not denial. It is the mind finding one small handhold on a wall with no handholds, and holding on.

A joke in the dark is a hand on the rope.

17. Juno — The Waiting Room Leaks

On the tenth night back, walking in the dark to save water, we reviewed the afterlife.

It was Abe's idea, or mine. I cannot remember. We were both so tired our mouths were doing things without us. His heart was going like shoes in a dryer and he would not talk about it, so we talked about this instead.

"One star," I said. "No parking."

"Two stars," Abe said. "The chairs were bolted together. I respect a chair that's bolted together. You know where you stand."

"You don't stand. You sit. That's the whole problem. Nobody ever says, *Juno Marrow, come on back.*"

"The magazines," Abe said. "There was a *Reader's Digest* from before I was born. I read a whole article about a man who was struck by lightning seven times. I thought, this is a message. I didn't know what it was."

"I'd leave a comment card," I said. "But there's no pen. There's never a pen."

"Would not die there again."

"Would not recommend."

We laughed in the dark until he had to stop and put his hands on his knees, and I stood next to him and waited and did not say anything about the sound his breathing made. When he could walk again we walked again. I did not know yet that we were going to be reviewing it in person in a few days. I would like to think that if I had known, I would still have made the joke about the pen.

I probably would have made it twice.

On the eleventh day back we came over the pass and down into Panamint Valley, and the light was wrong.

I want to be careful how I say this, too.

It was evening. The sun had gone down behind the mountains we had just crossed. Normally, when the sun goes down, the heat shimmer goes away and everything gets sharp and still and blue.

The shimmer did not go away.

It hung on the valley floor in the dusk, a low wavering layer like heat off a road. Not water. Not a mirage. Like the whole valley floor was a picture someone was holding up, and their hands were shaking.

And there was a sound, very faint, under the wind. A hum. A thin electric hum, like a fluorescent light that needs a new tube. In a ceiling. In a room.

I stopped walking. Abe stopped behind me with the one-eyed mule.

"Do you hear that," I said.

He did not say anything. I turned around. He was standing very still, with his head a little on one side, the way the raven had.

"Yeah," he said.

We stood there. The hum went on. The light shook.

Then I smelled it. That was the worst part. It came on a little breath of wind from down the valley, and it was not creosote, the little greasy bush that covers this desert, or dust or salt. It was carpet. The thin gray industrial kind they put in clinics and the waiting rooms of places nobody wants to be, walked on by ten thousand people in bad shoes. Carpet and burnt coffee and air that has been breathed by too many people and never let out.

I knew that smell. I had smelled it for one minute and something, when I was nine.

"Abe," I said.

"I know," he said.

"Is this—"

"I don't know."

"It's the same," I said. "It's the same place."

"I know," he said again. His voice was very quiet. "Bad lighting."

"Nobody called my name," I said.

And we both laughed. I do not know how. We stood on the edge of Panamint Valley at dusk with the waiting room leaking up out of the

ground in front of us like steam out of a grate, and we laughed, two dead people, two very small sharp laughs, the way you laugh at a funeral when something goes wrong.

Then the wind changed, and the smell was gone, and the shimmer settled down into the ordinary dark, and the hum stopped, or I stopped hearing it.

We made camp. We did not talk about it. I lay in my sleeping bag and looked at the stars and told myself it was the heat. It was the tiredness, the not-enough-water. It was a mind that had been walking for thirty days making rooms out of nothing. Everything I told myself was true.

I lay awake for a long time. And when I finally slept, I could still hear it, very faint, under the wind.

18. Abe — Lyle's Fire

Two nights later we camped at the mouth of the canyon.

I had not told her where we were. I had been walking toward it for two days and had not said a word. But she knew. She looked up at the cliffs and then at me, and she did not ask.

It is a side canyon off the main one. You would not look at it twice. A gravel floor, a little dry waterfall, cliffs on both sides the color of an old scab. About a mile up, there is a place where the left-hand cliff leans out and makes a long shade in the afternoon. That is where I left him.

I did not go up there. I sat at the mouth of the canyon with my back to it and ate cold beans out of the can and did not taste them.

Juno sat across from me. She did not make a fire. She did not say anything. She was being kind, which is the hardest thing to watch someone do for you.

When it was full dark, I saw the fire.

It was up the canyon. A mile, maybe. Small. Orange. Flickering against the cliff where the cliff leans out. A little campfire, the size of a man's two hands, the kind you make with dead creosote when you are cold and alone and waiting for a truck.

I looked at it for a long time.

"Juno," I said.

She turned. She looked where I was looking. I watched her face. I watched her see it.

"It's a mirage," I said. "Heat. Light bending. There's a word for it."

"Sure," she said.

"Or campers."

"Sure."

"Nobody camps up there. There's no reason to."

"Abe."

"I know who it is," I said.

She did not say anything. She reached across the dark and found my hand, and held it, and I let her. It was the first time I had let anybody hold my hand since my mother in the hospital in 1996. Her hand was hard and dry and very strong, and we sat there together and watched the little fire up against the cliff, burning, steady, patient, the way a light in a window burns for somebody who is late.

It burned all night. I know because I did not sleep.

In the morning, there was nothing up there. I knew there would not be. I did not go and look.

As we walked away down the wash, Juno said, very quietly, without looking at me, "He kept it going a long time."

I could not answer her. She did not need me to.

19. Juno — The Camp

We came down into Death Valley on the fifteenth day back.

The sign was still on the cliff at Badwater. SEA LEVEL. You could not see it from out there, but I knew where it was now, a white speck on the brown rock, high, impossibly high, like a note somebody had pinned to the top of the world.

It was November now, the month the valley is supposed to cool. It had not cooled. The floor was white and burning and the shimmer stood up off it all day and, at dusk, did not lie down.

Abe walked behind the mule, very slowly. His lips were gray. He stopped every few hundred yards with his hand flat on his chest and stood there, and I stood there, and the one-eyed mule stood there with its marker eye looking surprised at the mountains, and then he would nod and we would go on.

The hum was back. All day. A thin bright buzz under everything. I could feel it in my fillings.

We came to the spring late in the afternoon. The camp. Bennett's Well. The place we had started, thirty-four days before.

They were there.

I want to say this as simply as I can, because there is no other way to say it.

The families were there.

They were sitting in the shade of the mesquite, the way you would sit in a waiting room. Some on the ground. Some on wooden boxes. There was a wagon, one, gray, with its cover torn and the ribs showing like an animal's. There were men in long coats gone the color of dust, and women in bonnets, and children. A little boy with a stick, drawing in the dirt. A girl holding a smaller girl. An ox, huge and patient, lying down with its legs folded under it, chewing nothing, and I knew without being told that his name was Crump.

They were thin. All of them. So thin. And they were patient, so patient, sitting there the way people sit when they have been waiting so long they have forgotten what for.

The light over them was wrong. It was not sunlight. It was the color of fluorescent light, flat and gray-white, coming from nowhere, and it hummed.

A woman in a bonnet looked up as we came in. She had a kind face, worn down to the bone. She looked at Abe, and then at me, and then she smiled, and moved over a little on her box, and patted the space beside her.

There's shade, she said.

I heard it. I am telling you I heard it. And it was the Shade Seller's voice. It was his exact voice, coming out of her mouth.

Abe made a sound beside me. Not a word. A sound like something tearing.

There was a man standing at the edge of the shade, away from the others. A young man. Younger than Abe by far. Big through the shoulders, with a Marine haircut grown out a little, in a faded T-shirt, an old field jacket knotted around his waist by the sleeves. One of his boots was unlaced and his ankle was wrapped in a bandage gone brown. He was standing on it. It did not seem to bother him.

He was looking at Abe. He did not look angry. He looked like a man seeing an old friend come in through the door of a bar.

"Hey, Coldiron," he said.

Abe did not move.

"Took you long enough," Lyle said, and smiled.

I could not watch it. I looked away.

And that was when I saw her.

She was sitting by herself at the far edge of the camp, where the shade ran out. On the ground, in the dirt, with her knees pulled up. A little girl. Nine years old, maybe. Thin legs. Dirty sneakers, the kind with lights in the heels, but the lights were dead. A T-shirt much too big for her, a teenager's, yellow, with a cartoon on the front faded almost to nothing. Her hair was stuck to her head with sweat.

She was not looking at me. She was looking at her hands. Her fingers. She was holding them up in front of her face, turning them, looking at the nails.

The nails were broken. All of them. Torn down to the quick.

She would not look at me.

I knew that T-shirt. It had been Kit's.

V. SALT

Interlude Viii — The Memory That Rewrites Itself

For a long time, people thought memory worked like a filing cabinet. Something happens, the mind writes it down, and the page goes in a drawer, and it does not change.

It does change.

A scientist named Elizabeth Loftus spent fifty years showing how much. She found that a single word in a question — smashed instead of hit — could make people remember a car crash as faster than it was, and remember broken glass that was never there. Other scientists found that every time we bring a memory up, the mind rebuilds it, and puts the rebuilt version away, not the original. Remember something a hundred times and you have rebuilt it a hundred times, and each time a little of what you needed it to be gets mixed in.

And there is something stranger. A psychologist named Ronnie Janoff-Bulman found that people who have been through something terrible very often blame themselves for it, even when there was nothing they could have done. It seems cruel. It is not. If it was your fault, then you had some control. If you had control, then next time you can stop it. And then the world is not a place where things simply happen to you while you watch.

Being guilty is terrible. Being helpless is worse.

Sometimes the mind would rather be guilty than helpless. Guilt at least gives you something to hold.

20. Juno — The Girl in the T-Shirt

I walked over to her.

It was not far. Thirty steps, maybe. Across the edge of the camp, past the wagon with its ribs showing, past the boy drawing in the dirt with his stick, who did not look up. It took me a very long time. The minute opened up in front of me the way minutes had been opening for a month, and I walked into it, and every step was a room.

The hum was louder here. The light was flatter. The ground under my boots was not gravel anymore. It was carpet. Thin gray carpet, worn into paths. I could feel it give.

I sat down in front of her. Cross-legged, in the dirt, on the carpet, whatever it was. Close enough to touch. I did not touch her.

She was still looking at her hands.

Up close I could see everything. The sweat on her upper lip. A smear of something red on her chin, a Popsicle maybe, from before. The dead lights in her sneakers. The yellow T-shirt, Kit's T-shirt, with a cartoon dog on it, faded nearly white, the neck stretched out so it hung off one of her shoulders. I had worn that shirt until it fell apart. I had forgotten it existed. I had forgotten that I had ever been this small.

Her fingers. The nails torn down to the pink. There was dried blood at the corners, brown, and a little bit of something under the nails, gray, like rubber, or vinyl.

"Hey," I said.

She did not answer.

"I know you," I said.

She turned her hands over. Looked at the palms. Turned them back.

"I'm sorry," I said. My voice came out wrong. "I'm sorry I didn't just get out. I could have just gotten out. I should have opened the door. If I had opened the door, none of it—"

She looked up at me.

Her eyes. I do not know how to tell you about her eyes. They were my eyes, but they were nine, and they were very, very tired, the way only a child who has been waiting a long time can be tired. They looked at me like I had said something stupid. Not cruel. Just stupid. The way you look at a grownup who has got everything backwards.

She held up her hands. Close to my face. So I could see.

And I saw.

I saw the inside of the Buick. The tan seats, cracked, hot enough to burn. The windows up. The air like the inside of a mouth. I saw the door handle, the chrome one on the back door, and I saw my own small hand on it, pulling. Pulling. The handle moving and the door not opening. Because the back doors had the child locks on. Because Mom had put them on years before, when I was little, because I used to open the door on the freeway. Because the back doors of that Buick did not open from the inside. They had never opened from the inside.

I saw myself climb over into the front. I saw the front doors. The lock knobs, pushed down, sunk deep in the doors. I saw myself pull and pull at the front handle, and it did not open either, because the lock was down and the knob was too slippery and too small and my hands were wet, and I was nine.

I saw myself at the window. Scratching at the window. Clawing at the rubber seal around the glass, trying to get my fingers into it, trying to pull the glass down with my nails, the way you try anything when there is nothing to try. I saw the nails bend back and break. I saw the blood on the rubber.

I heard myself screaming. I had never remembered screaming. I screamed until there was nothing left to scream with. And people walked by. In the parking lot of the Rite Aid. People walked by, in the heat, looking at their phones, carrying bags, and nobody heard. Or nobody looked.

And then I saw myself stop. Lie down on the seat. Very tired. The seat burning my cheek. And the light in the car going flat and gray-white, and a hum starting, and the smell of carpet.

The girl put her hands down.

I could not open the door.

I could never open the door.

I had not sat there because I wanted to be good. I had not stayed because he told me to wait. I had not chosen anything. I had fought that car with everything a nine-year-old has, and the car had won, and nobody came. Nobody came for a long, long time.

And afterwards — after the stranger with the rock, after the ambulance and the hospital and the foster homes and Kit taken away — afterwards, some part of me had taken that afternoon and quietly turned it around. Turned it inside out like a shirt. *You could have gotten out. You chose to stay. It was you. You did it.* For eighteen years I had believed it. I had built my whole life on it, the way you build a house on a floor. I had believed that I was the one who did something wrong, because the truth was that I was the one nothing could be done for. That I was small, and locked in, and screaming, and nobody came.

I would rather have been guilty.

God, I would rather have been guilty.

I do not know how long I sat there. The minute did not end. The girl sat across from me with her broken hands in her lap, and she was not crying, and neither was I, at first. Then I was. Not the way I cry, quietly, so nobody hears. The other way. The way I had not cried since I was nine. The way that comes from the bottom of something and takes your whole body with it.

The girl watched me. After a while she reached out, very slowly, and put one broken finger on the back of my hand. Just one. Light as a fly.

It was hot. Her finger was hot like the inside of that car.

I turned my hand over and held hers. Her whole hand fit inside my palm. I held it the way you hold something you have been looking for under every piece of furniture in the house for eighteen years.

“Okay,” I said. “Okay. I’m here. I’m here now.”

It was a stupid thing to say. It was the only thing.

She did not answer. But she leaned forward, a little, the way a tired child leans, until her forehead was against my shoulder. And she stayed there. And I stayed.

Somewhere behind me, across the camp, a long way off, I heard Abe say my name.

21. Abe — The Asking

I do not know how long I stood in front of Lyle.

He looked the way he looked the morning I left him. Thirty-two. Sunburned across the nose. That stupid grown-out haircut he was always going to cut and never did. He was standing on the broken ankle like it was nothing. Behind him the families sat in the gray light and waited.

"You came," he said.

"Nineteen years late."

"Yeah. That's a lot of late." He grinned. "Did you bring the truck?"

"I brought a deer cart."

"Outstanding," Lyle said, in my voice, exactly my voice, and I laughed, and the laugh broke in the middle and turned into something else.

"I'm sorry," I said. "Lyle. I said I'd be back by morning."

"You'd have been back by morning," he said. "Your heart had other plans. I know. I was half in here already, sitting under that cliff. I saw you come through. The first time. You walked right past me. Didn't even say hi." He tapped his chest. "We all saw you, man. You were here four minutes. You looked like you'd lost your car keys."

I could not say anything.

"I wrote on the rock," he said. "You see that?"

"They told me."

"*Abe coming.*" He shook his head. "I didn't write it so they'd blame you. I wrote it so they'd know I wasn't alone. I wasn't sitting there waiting for you to save me. I was sitting there knowing somebody was trying. That's different. That's a lot different, Abe."

My heart was falling down the stairs. Hard now. The pennies in my mouth. My hands were cold and the cold was coming up my arms.

"You walked out," Lyle said. "And now you walked back in. That's the whole story. That's both halves. Nobody reads the sequel. You did." He looked over my shoulder. "Now you've got to walk somebody out. That's how it ends. Everybody walks out together."

Behind him, the families were standing up. All of them. Slowly, stiffly, the way people stand after sitting a long time. The women shaking out their skirts. The men lifting the children. The big ox getting his back legs under him and then his front. They were looking west, at the mountains. Toward the pass.

And then the ground came up.

I did not fall the way you fall in the movies. My knees just stopped. I sat down on the carpet, on the gravel, on whatever it was, and then I was lying on my side, and my cheek was on something hot and gritty. The light went flat. My heart was not falling down the stairs anymore. It was at the bottom of the stairs, lying there, twitching.

Oliver was in my ear. *Get up, Coldiron. Get up. Is that it? Is that the show?*

And the other voice, under him. The quiet one. The one from the valley with the railroad.

You could ask.

I have been asked for help a thousand times. I have carried men. I have given men water out of my own canteen. I have done CPR on a stranger on the shoulder of the 15, the Vegas freeway. I have never, once, in fifty-one years, asked anybody for anything. Not my father. Not my mother. Not the Marine Corps. Not God. It was the only record I still held.

I could hear Juno coming. Running, over the gravel. I could hear her saying my name, again and again, in a voice I had not heard her use.

Her face came down over mine, upside down, blotting out the gray light.

I opened my mouth. It took everything. Everything I had left.

"Juno," I said. "Carry me."

22. Juno — The Mule

The truck was where we had left it, thirty-four days before, at the edge of the camp, white with dust. The note was still on the dash. GONE WALKING. BACK IN FIVE WEEKS. DON'T TOW.

I took his keys out of his pocket and ran to it. I got in and turned the key and the truck said *click*. Just *click*. Like a tongue against teeth. Five weeks in the heat. The battery was dead.

I sat in the driver's seat for one second with my hands on the wheel.

Don't tow, I thought. *Very funny, Abe.*

No signal. There is never signal at the spring. The road ran past the camp, a pale strip of gravel, empty in both directions, and the dark coming down. Thirteen miles to Badwater, north up the gravel and then east across the salt. No headlights. Nothing.

So I did what you do.

I unstrapped the water jugs from the one-eyed mule. I laid the pack frame and the tarp across the cart, the way the hunters do it, a bed on two wheels. I got Abe onto it. I do not know how. He is two hundred pounds and I am a hundred and thirty-five. I got my arms under his arms from behind and I dragged him and lifted him and swore at him and he helped a little, with his legs, and then he did not help at all. I strapped him on with the deer straps. His face was gray. His lips were blue in the headlamp. He was breathing. Little shallow breaths, like a dog asleep.

I picked up the handles. I leaned forward into them, and I walked out onto the road, north, toward Badwater. Toward the lowest place in America. Down.

The wheels made a sound on the gravel like rain. Behind me, at the camp, I did not look. I did not need to. I knew they were standing up. All of them. I knew the girl in the yellow shirt was standing at the edge of the shade, watching me go. I knew Lyle was there with his hands in his pockets.

The Shade Seller came at mile two.

He did not walk beside me this time. He was everywhere. He was the whole night.

Put him down, he said. Very gently. He's dying. He's going to die whether you drag him or not. Leave him by the road. Somebody will find him in the morning. You can walk to Badwater by midnight without him. Somebody has to live.

All true.

He's not your father, the Shade Seller said. He's not your brother. You knew him for five weeks. He paid you. You don't owe him anything.

True.

The girl, he said. Leave the girl too. You don't have to carry that. Put it all down on the side of the road and walk away and nobody will ever, ever know. There's shade. There's so much shade. Look.

And he showed me. Pictures of water. One after another, all along the road. A motel pool, blue and glowing. The swimming pool in Delano, when I was ten. A bus to Vegas with its lights on. The tan Buick at the edge of a lake. A door, open, with a cool dark room behind it, and nobody in it, and nothing to carry.

I did not argue with him.

That was the thing I learned that night. You cannot win an argument with him. He has had your whole life to practice. Every reason he gives you is true.

Somewhere around mile four I remembered Abe's jar.

He had told me about it on the walk back in, one night in the wash, embarrassed, as if he were confessing he still slept with a stuffed animal. I had laughed at him. Now I took the lid off mine.

I had never known I had one. But it turned out things had been going in there anyway, for years. A Silverado on Union Avenue at three in the morning, with a pit bull on a chain. The fight in Fresno where my eye closed in the second round and I fought the third by sound. Two hundred and fifty miles to a theme park. The drum solo under my fingers. The girl in the yellow shirt, holding my hand.

You did that, I told myself. That was you. This is smaller than that.

It was not smaller. It was much bigger. It did not matter. It worked anyway.

Then I did the other thing he told me. I looked ahead. Not at the road. All the way. I made myself see it: the sign on the cliff at Badwater, white in the first light, and headlights coming down the road, and Abe's face with color in it. I kept it there, in front of me, a picture of water I had painted myself, and I walked toward it.

So I let the Shade Seller talk, every single word, and I did not answer, and I did not stop walking. Step. Step. The wheels like rain. The handles cutting into my palms until my palms bled and the blood made the handles slippery, and I wrapped my shirt around them and went on in my bra in the dark like a crazy woman, and I did not stop.

He talked for hours.

And then, somewhere around midnight, somewhere around mile ten, he started to repeat himself.

I noticed it the way you notice a song on the radio has come around again. *Put him down. You don't owe him. There's shade.* He had said all of that. Nothing new was coming. It was the same mail, over and over, and I had already read it all.

I stopped opening it.

And then, about an hour later, he stopped. Not because I beat him. Because he had nothing left to sell. He had emptied his whole cart out on the road in front of me, and I had walked past every single thing in it.

He did not leave. I do not think he ever leaves. But he went quiet. And in the quiet, for the first time in my life, I heard something else.

It was not a voice. It was just my own breathing. My feet. The wheels. The man on the cart behind me, breathing too, still breathing. The stars. The salt hissing as it cooled.

It was very loud, and it was very calm. And I was in it. All the way in. Not visiting. Not waiting to leave.

I was living there.

I laughed out loud, alone, on the gravel road, at nothing. I could not have told you what was funny. Something was.

Interlude IX — The Salt That Stays

When a person first walks into great heat, the body panics a little. The heart races. The sweat pours, so salty you can see it dry white on your shirt. The body is throwing away its salt in a hurry, the way a frightened person throws everything out of a boat.

But if the person stays, day after day, the body begins to learn. Within a week or two, the heart beats slower in the same heat. The body sweats sooner, and more. And the sweat itself carries less salt. The body has learned to hold on to what it needs. Scientists who study soldiers and athletes have measured it again and again.

It cannot learn this anywhere else. Not in the shade. Not in a cool room reading about heat. Only in the heat, by staying.

People who stay in hard places change in a similar way. Not all at once. The fear does not leave. The pain does not stop hurting. But slowly the body stops panicking. It stops throwing everything overboard. It learns what to keep.

The salt on your skin is the bill for staying.

It is also the receipt.

23. Abe — Somebody Called My Name

I was in the waiting room again.

Same light. Flat and gray-white, from nowhere. Same hum, in the ceiling, in the walls, in my teeth. Same carpet, thin and gray, worn into paths by ten thousand people in bad shoes. Same smell of burnt coffee and breathed air. Same chairs, the plastic ones joined together in rows, orange, with a little shelf at the end with magazines on it. I looked at the magazines. They were the same magazines. Nineteen years, and nobody had changed the magazines.

I sat down. Where else would you sit.

There were other people. Not many. A woman in a bonnet with her hands in her lap. A man in a long coat looking at the floor. A little boy, swinging his legs, drawing on the carpet with his finger.

And Lyle. In the chair next to mine. Like we had come in together.

"Hey," he said.

"Hey."

"Told you the magazines were bad."

"You never told me that."

"I'm telling you now." He picked one up and showed me. A *Field and Stream* from 1987. "I've read this four hundred times. There's an article about bass. I know more about bass than any man alive."

I laughed. It did not hurt here. Nothing hurt here. My heart was not falling down the stairs. My heart was not doing anything. It was very quiet in my chest, and the quiet was nice, and I understood how a man could sit in that chair for a long time and not mind.

"This is the shade," I said.

"Yeah," Lyle said. "This is the best shade there is."

We sat. The light hummed. The little boy drew on the carpet.

"I like it here," I said.

"I know you do," Lyle said. "That's why you've got to go."

He stood up. He had his old Marine field jacket on, the one with the name tape torn off, the one they had found him in. He took it off. He held it out to me.

"It's cold out there," he said. "Where you're going. Nights get cold in November."

"Lyle."

"Take the coat, Abe."

I took the coat. It was warm from him.

"Somebody's going to call your name," he said. "Pretty soon. Pretty loud. I'd answer, if I were you."

"How do you know?"

"Because I can hear her," Lyle said, and grinned. "She's been yelling for twenty minutes. She's got a mouth on her, Coldiron. She's using words I didn't learn in the Corps."

And then I heard it too.

From very far away. From above. Through the ceiling, through the hum, through nineteen years.

ABE.

Not a nice voice. Furious. Hoarse. Ragged. A voice that had been screaming for a long time and had a lot more screaming in it.

ABE. ABE COLDIRON. DON'T YOU DARE. DON'T YOU DARE, YOU GRAY IDIOT. ABE.

And with it, a thump. A thump in my chest, from outside. Hard. And another. And another. Somebody pushing on me, hard and fast, a hundred times a minute, the way they teach you, the way I had done it on the shoulder of the 15. Every thump, the waiting room shook a little. The magazines slid on the shelf. The light flickered.

ABE. YOU ASKED. YOU ASKED ME. YOU DON'T GET TO ASK AND THEN LEAVE. ABE.

Lyle sat back down. He picked up his *Field and Stream*. He opened it to the article about bass.

"Somebody called your name," he said, without looking up. "Go on."

I stood up. I had the coat in my hands.

"Lyle—"

"Go on, Abe. I'm fine. I've got bass."

I looked at him one more time. At the stupid haircut, and the sunburned nose, and the ankle in its brown bandage, propped up on the chair across from him like a man at home.

Then I turned around and walked toward the voice.

The light got brighter. Real light. Hard, and orange, and coming from one side. The hum turned into something else, a roaring, a wind. The carpet turned to salt, rough and cold under my cheek. And the thumps in my chest stopped being something outside me and became my own heart, kicking, once, twice, and catching, the way an old truck catches, and then going. Going.

I opened my eyes.

Juno was kneeling over me in the dawn, on the salt, with no shirt on and her hands bloody and her hair stuck to her face. Behind her, high on the brown cliff, small as a postage stamp, there was a white sign.

She was crying and swearing at the same time. I did not know a person could do both at once.

I tried to say *outstanding*. It came out as a sort of croak.

"Don't," she said. "Don't you *dare*."

24. Juno — Goodbye

The ranger came at six-forty. A Park Service truck, white with a green stripe, coming down the road from Furnace Creek, the park's little headquarters town up the valley, on his morning drive to check the bathrooms at Badwater. A young guy with a mustache he had not earned yet. He saw us from a quarter mile off — a woman in a bra kneeling beside a man laid out on the salt next to a deer cart — and he hit the lights.

He had a radio. He had oxygen. He had one of those machines that talk to you and tell you when to shock. Abe did not need the shock.

Abe's heart was going on its own by then, going badly, falling down stairs, but going. The ranger put the mask on him. He called it in. He kept looking at me.

"Ma'am," he said. "Where did you come from?"

"The spring," I said. "Bennett's Well."

"That's thirteen miles."

"Yes."

"You pulled him thirteen miles?"

"He asked," I said.

The helicopter came at seven-thirty. It came down out of the sky over the Black Mountains with the sun behind it and landed on the road, and the noise and the wind were enormous, salt blowing everywhere, and two people in flight suits ran out with a stretcher and put Abe on it.

Before they took him, he opened his eyes. He looked at me. His face under the oxygen mask was gray and old and his eyes were very clear. He had something clutched in one hand. A jacket. An old field jacket with the name tape torn off. I had seen it once before, knotted around a young man's waist at the spring. I still do not know how it got into Abe's hand.

He could not talk. But he lifted two fingers off the stretcher, a little salute. And I lifted two back.

Then they took him up into the sky.

I stood on the salt and watched the helicopter until it was nothing, going east, toward Las Vegas. The ranger stood beside me. He gave me a bottle of water and a Park Service windbreaker with a patch on the shoulder, and I put it on. My hands were shaking so hard I could not hold the bottle and he held it for me. I told him about the white truck back at the spring with the dead battery and the note on the dash. He said he would send somebody down to jump it. He said it the way you say something to a person who might fall over.

When the noise was gone, it was very quiet.

I turned around and looked at the valley. The whole of it. In the early light, it was gold and white and enormous, the salt going away

to the south in great broken plates, the mountains on both sides lit pink at their tops. Somewhere down there, thirteen miles south, was a spring with a little green around it, and some mesquite, and a dead white truck, and a camp.

I could not see them from there. I did not need to.

I knew they had walked out. I knew they had all stood up, and the ox had got its legs under it, and the children had been lifted, and they had walked west, toward the pass. I knew a young man with a broken ankle was walking with them, and that it did not hurt him. I knew a girl in a yellow T-shirt was walking too. I did not know where she was walking to. I hoped it was somewhere with a pool.

There was salt on my arms. White. Crusted. All the way up to the elbows. On my face, I could feel it, on my lips. The salt of thirty-five days, the salt of the road last night, all of it, dried white in the sun.

I said it out loud. I did not mean to. It just came out, the way it must have come out of somebody's mouth in 1850, standing at the top of the last mountain, looking back.

"Goodbye, Death Valley," I said.

The ranger looked at me.

"It's a thing people say," I told him.

25. Abe — Rent

They kept me in Las Vegas for nine days. Then in Loma Linda [LOH-mah LIN-dah], at the big heart hospital east of Los Angeles, for another eleven. They put a little machine in my chest the size of a matchbox, with a wire into my heart, that will shock it if it ever stops again. They closed the hole I was born with, using a little umbrella on a wire, through a vein in my leg. It looked like something you would put on a Christmas tree.

Juno came every day. She drove out in my truck, which the rangers had jumped for her, and which, technically, she had repossessed. She sat in the chair by the bed with her feet up on the rail and ate my Jell-O.

"So," she said, the first day. "What was it like."

"Waiting room," I said. "Bad lighting."

"Did they call your name?"

"Somebody did."

"Was it a nice voice?"

"No," I said. "It was the worst voice I ever heard. It used words they don't teach in the Corps."

She looked pleased with herself. "Noted," she said.

On the fifth day she brought me sunflower seeds. On the seventh she brought me a tiny plastic mule from a gift shop, gray, with a sad face, and drew a single eye on it with a pen and put it on the tray table, where it watched me eat.

On the ninth day I told her about the house.

I did not plan to. It was late, and the hospital was quiet in the way hospitals are quiet, which is not quiet at all.

"I built a house down there," I said. "Nineteen years ago, when I walked out on Lyle. Below sea level. That's what I call it now, the place I go. I built a house in the worst place I knew and I moved in. I thought that was what you did. You go to the hard place and you stay. You make it your home. I've been living there ever since."

"I know," Juno said.

"I thought that made me strong. All the races. Badwater. I thought I was the hardest man alive because I could live down there." I looked at the ceiling. "I wasn't living there because I was strong. I was living there because I owed rent. Every mile was a payment. Nineteen years of payments. Never once did I think I'd paid enough."

She was quiet for a while.

"You asked me," she said. "On the salt. You asked me to carry you."

"Yeah."

"First time?"

"First time in my life."

"How did it feel?"

I thought about it for a long time. "Like the worst thing that ever happened to me," I said. "And like setting something down."

She nodded. She put her hand on the rail of the bed, near mine, not touching.

"The rent's paid, Abe," she said.

I looked at her. She meant it. She meant it with her whole face. I loved her for it. I loved her the way you love a person who has dragged you thirteen miles through the dark and then come back every day to eat your Jell-O.

"No, it isn't," I said. "That's the thing nobody tells you. It's never paid. You don't get to own a house down there. You only rent. You pay every day you live in it." I turned my hand over on the blanket. "But you can pay it with somebody else. It turns out that's allowed. I didn't know that. Nobody told me that was allowed."

Juno looked at my hand, palm up on the blanket. Then she put hers in it.

We sat like that until the nurse came in to do my numbers. Then we let go, and Juno ate the last of the Jell-O, and the little one-eyed mule watched us from the tray table with its one drawn eye, surprised, as always, at everything.

26. Juno — Below Sea Level

I played it in a motel room outside Barstow.

The Desert Sands Motor Lodge, room nine. Abe had gone home that afternoon to his house in Barstow with his new heart and his little machine and his field jacket, which he would not take off and would not explain. I had driven him there and carried his bag in, and at the door he had asked me to stay for dinner, because he asks for things now. He is not exactly the old Abe anymore. I said not tonight. I said I had a thing.

I had a thing.

The room had a bed with a brown cover and a painting of a sailboat over it, and a window unit that rattled, and a carpet that was thin and gray and worn into paths. I noticed the carpet. I made myself

notice it, and I made myself stay, and I sat down on the end of the bed in my boots.

There was still salt in the creases of my hands. I had washed and washed and it was still there, white in the lines of my palms.

Then I took out the phone.

The little red number. One. Two years and fifty-one days.

I pressed it. I held the phone to my ear. I heard the click. I heard him breathe in.

And this time I did not press stop.

Hey. Juno. It's — it's Kit. I don't know if this is still your number. A lady at the county gave it to me. She wasn't supposed to.

His voice was older. Deeper. Rough at the edges like something that had been sanded by hand. But it was his. I would have known it at the bottom of the ocean.

I'm — okay. I'm going to just say it. I'm in a program. I've been sober eleven months. Part of it is, you're supposed to — you're supposed to go to the people. And say it. So I'm saying it.

A breath. A long one. I could hear a car go by wherever he was. I could hear a dog.

That day. At the Rite Aid. I wasn't stealing. I mean I was. I was stealing. But I got caught right away. Like ten minutes in. And the guy took me in the back and he was going to call the cops and I was so scared, Juno. I was fourteen. And I didn't tell him. I didn't tell him you were in the car. I kept thinking I'd get out, I'd talk my way out, I'd get back before — and I didn't tell him. For three hours I didn't tell him.

The window unit rattled. I did not move.

And then I heard the sirens. From the back room. And I knew. I knew it was for you. And I still — I sat there. I just sat there. And I let them come.

He stopped. For a long time there was only breathing. His and mine. I realized I was breathing with him. Two years apart.

I'm sorry I left you in the car.

He said it very simply. Like a man setting something heavy on a floor.

I'm sorry I left you in the car. It was me. It was never you. I need you to know that, even if you never — even if you don't call. It was me. You were nine. You couldn't — those doors didn't even open. Mom put the locks on. You couldn't have gotten out. You know that, right? I don't know what they told you. I don't know what you told yourself. It wasn't you, Juno.

I'm in Bakersfield. On Ming. The blue house by the 99. If you ever — I'm here. I'm just here. Okay.

Okay. Bye.

The click.

I sat there.

I played it again.

I played it eleven times. I know because I counted. I sat on the end of the bed with the sailboat over my head and the carpet under my boots and I played it again and again, until I knew every breath in it, every car going by, the dog, the place where his voice went up like a boy's on the word *nine*.

Then I got up and got in the truck. Abe's truck. The job was to bring it in, and I was bringing it in, the long way, by way of a blue house on Ming.

It is a hundred and thirty miles from Barstow to Bakersfield. West on the 58, over the Tehachapis [tuh-HATCH-uh-pee], the mountains that wall off the Central Valley, and down into it. I drove it that night like I had never seen it.

The Shade Seller got in at Boron, the borax-mine town an hour out.

I had not heard him since the cart. I had thought maybe he was gone. He is never gone. He got in on the passenger side like an old friend, and he was gentle, gentler than he had ever been, because he knew this was the last chance he was going to get.

You don't have to go tonight, he said. It's late. Go in the morning. Or text him. Let him come to you.

True.

He left you in that car for three hours, Juno. He heard the sirens and he sat there. You don't owe him a knock on his door. You don't owe him anything.

True.

You've been through enough. Turn around. Go back to Barstow. Abe asked you to dinner. Be happy for once. There's shade, Juno. Look how much shade.

All true. He had never lied to me. Not once.

I pulled over in the Tehachapis, on the shoulder, with the big rigs going by and shaking the cab. I sat with my hands on the wheel and let him talk. I did not argue. I let him say every true thing, and let each one land, and I did not answer.

Then I laughed. I do not know what at. At him, maybe. At me. At a woman sitting on the shoulder of the 58 at eleven at night, with salt in her hands, listening to nobody, and losing, and going anyway.

"Noted," I said out loud, to the empty passenger seat.

And I pulled back out onto the road.

I am going to tell you what I knew, on that drive down out of the mountains, with the lights of Bakersfield coming up out of the dark ahead of me like something spilled.

I was not going there to be forgiven. There was nothing to forgive me for. That was what the girl had shown me with her broken nails.

And I was not going there to forgive him. I did not know if I could. Maybe someday. I still cannot tell you.

I was going because the truth was worse than the lie, and I had to stand in it. For eighteen years I had kept myself out of that car by telling myself I chose to be in it.

The truth was that I was small, and locked in, and I screamed, and nobody came. That is the worst place I know. Lower than Badwater. Lower than anything with a sign.

And I was driving into it on purpose. Not to fix it. You cannot fix it. Just to stand in it with my eyes open, and not leave. To live there for a while, and find out what kind of house a person can build at the bottom of everything.

Ming Avenue at one in the morning. The 99, the big valley freeway, roaring behind the houses like the sea. A blue house with a chain-link fence and a light on over the porch, a yellow bug light, with moths going around it.

I parked. I got out. I walked up the path.

The porch had three steps. They were concrete, and one of them was cracked, and there was a pot of something dead at the top of them. There was a doormat that said nothing. There was a screen door with a hole in it near the bottom, where a dog had pushed through.

I stood on the doormat.

My heart was going so hard I could feel it in my teeth. The way Abe's went, that night in the mountains, falling down the stairs. I stood there and let it go. I did not try to stop it.

I thought about the sign at Badwater. That little white sign, way up on the cliff. SEA LEVEL. And all of us down underneath it, looking up.

Bakersfield is four hundred feet above the sea. I looked it up once, at the tow yard, on a slow night. Four hundred feet up.

I have never been lower in my life.

The Shade Seller did not say anything. He was standing on the step behind me. But he had nothing left to sell. He had shown me every picture of water he owned. He had given me every true reason in the world. And I was still here, on the mat, with the moths going around the light.

I looked at my hand.

There was still salt in it. White, in the lines of the palm. I could not get it out. I do not think I ever will.

I raised it, and I knocked.

I'm below sea level.

I think I'll stay a while.

GLOSSARY

Amargosa [aa-mar-GO-sah] — Spanish, *bitter*. The river that runs south out of Nevada and turns into Death Valley, where it sinks into the ground and does not come out.

Arcan, Jean-Baptiste [zhahn bah-TEEST ar-KAHN] — A Frenchman who waited at the 1849 camp with his wife Abigail and their small son Charles until Manly and Rogers came back for them.

Badwater — The lowest point in North America, a salt flat on the floor of Death Valley, 282 feet below sea level. A sign high on the cliff above it marks where the sea would be.

Below Sea Level — Abe's name for the hard place, which Juno takes up: the state the mind and body enter under great discomfort, of either kind, where everything sits lower than where you started and nothing drains away.

Bennett's Well — A spring on the floor of Death Valley, near the camp where the Bennett and Arcan families waited in the winter of 1849 for Manly and Rogers to return.

Black Mountains — The range on the east side of Death Valley, behind Badwater; the sun comes up over it.

Deer cart — A two-wheeled frame with handles, sold to hunters for dragging game out of rough country. Abe draws one eye on his and calls it the mule.

Delano [duh-LAY-noh] — A farm town in the Central Valley, north of Bakersfield.

Furnace Creek — The park's small headquarters town, up the valley from Badwater.

Goodbye, Death Valley — The words said to have been spoken by a member of the 1849 party as they climbed out of the valley for the last time, and the origin of its name.

A house down there — Staying in the hard place long enough to stop waiting to leave it; living in discomfort rather than visiting it. In Abe's words, a house you never own, only rent.

The jar — Abe's name for the place in his head where he keeps every hard thing he has come through, to take one out and look at it when he needs it.

Kosovo [KOH-soh-voh] — A small country in the Balkans, in south-eastern Europe, where American Marines were sent as peacekeepers in 1999.

Loma Linda [LOH-mah LIN-dah] — Spanish, *pretty hill*. A town east of Los Angeles with a large heart hospital.

Manly and Rogers — William Lewis Manly and John Rogers, the two young men who walked roughly two hundred and fifty miles out of Death Valley for help in the winter of 1849, and then walked back in to bring the families out.

Old Crump — The ox who carried the Bennett children out of Death Valley, and whom Asabel Bennett swore he would never eat.

Panamint — The mountain range on the west side of Death Valley, and the valley beyond it.

Pictures of Water — The mind's way of showing a way out: a pain that is not damage yet, a buried memory, a very good reason to stop. Named after the desert mirage, which is a piece of sky bent by heat until it lies on the ground.

Pristina [PRISH-tee-nah] — The capital of Kosovo.

Rancho San Francisco [RAHN-cho san fran-SIS-ko] — Spanish, *Saint Francis ranch*. The cattle ranch north of Los Angeles where Manly and Rogers found food in 1850. The ground near it now holds a theme park.

Salt — What is left on the skin when sweat burns off in great heat; in this book, what stays in a person who has stayed in the hard place.

The Shade Seller — Juno's name for the voice that wants you out of the hard place. He is friendly, patient and never lies. The shade he sells is real, and the price is that you stop walking.

Tehachapis [tuh-HATCH-uh-peeze] — The mountains between the Mojave Desert and the Central Valley, crossed by the 58 on the way to Bakersfield.

Trona — A company town on the edge of a dry lake west of Death Valley, where salt, soda and borax are taken out of the old lakebed.

Juno Marrow repossesses cars for a living and sleeps in whichever one she towed that week. Abe Coldiron fixes air conditioners in Barstow and walks across deserts for no reason anyone can name.

They meet in a motel parking lot in Baker, under the tallest thermometer in the world, when she comes to repossess his truck. He offers her a deal.

Walk out of Death Valley with him, on the route of 1849. Two hundred and fifty miles. Nobody she is running from will ever find her out there.

Both of them have died once. Both of them saw the same room.

Below sea level, a voice sells shade, the desert shows them water that is not there, and the walk out turns out to be the easy half.

You can live down there. You just never own it.

